

THE HILL

Episode 2 — “The Chicken Dinner”

Script Draft — Cold Open + Act One

Version 0.1

COLD OPEN

EXT. HORNER HOMESTEAD — DAWN

The same house.

The same ridge.

The same road.

Morning has arrived.

Nothing looks different enough.

That is the cruelty.

The yard is pale with first light.

Smoke begins to rise from the chimney.

A chicken scratches near the fence.

The field beyond the house waits under gray air.

The wooded hillside stands past it.

Close enough to look reachable.

Too far to trust.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — DAWN

John Samuel's eyes are open.

He has not slept.

Christopher sleeps beside him, mouth open, one hand curled around the scrap of wood from the day before.

Across the room, William is awake near the door.

Spencer sits at the table.

Permelia works the hearth.

Mary Ann moves quietly with a cup.

Nobody says good morning.

The day does not deserve it.

EXT. RIDGE ROAD — DAWN

Jess Wilson sits on his horse in the timber.

Not alone now.

Three riders behind him.

Maybe four.

Faces hidden by trees, hats, low light.

The borrowed auger still hangs from Jess's saddle.

The second rider watches the house below.

SECOND RIDER

They moving?

Jess studies the yard.

JESS

They're waking.

SECOND RIDER

Same thing.

Jess does not answer.

Below, William steps outside.

Jess sees him.

JESS

Wait.

EXT. HORNER YARD — DAWN

William steps into the yard.

He does not go far.

He listens.

The creek.

The chickens.

The wind.

Nothing useful.

Spencer appears behind him.

SPENCER

You hear all that waiting?

William does not look back.

WILLIAM

I hear what ain't moving.

Spencer steps beside him.

For a moment, father and son look at the ridge together.

Not arguing.

Just standing.

SPENCER

You think today.

WILLIAM

I think soon.

SPENCER

That ain't what I asked.

William finally looks at him.

WILLIAM

Then yes.

Spencer absorbs that.

No anger now.

Only the cost of believing too late.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — CONTINUOUS

Mary Ann watches them from inside.

Permelia watches Mary Ann watching them.

PERMELIA

Don't stand in the door.

Mary Ann steps back.

MARY ANN

I can't see from back here.

PERMELIA

That's why.

Mary Ann looks at her.

Understands.

The doorway is no longer a place to look from.

It is a place to be seen.

CUT TO BLACK.

TITLE CARD:

THE HILL

Episode Two: The Chicken Dinner

ACT ONE

EXT. LITTLE MULBERRY CREEK — MORNING

John Samuel carries the bucket again.

This time William walks with him.

Christopher starts to follow from the yard.

Mary Ann catches him.

MARY ANN

Not today.

CHRISTOPHER

I helped yesterday.

MARY ANN

Yesterday ain't today.

Christopher does not understand the sentence.

John Samuel does.

He looks back once.

Then follows William down toward the creek.

EXT. CREEK BANK — CONTINUOUS

William fills the bucket instead of John Samuel.

John Samuel watches the ridge reflected in the water.

The reflection breaks whenever the bucket moves.

JOHN SAMUEL

You think they know I seen them?

William stops.

WILLIAM

Who?

John Samuel does not answer.

William looks at the boy.

WILLIAM (CONT'D)

If you saw something, say it plain.

JOHN SAMUEL

I saw where something was.

That is different.

William understands.

He kneels so they are eye-level.

WILLIAM

You don't need to prove it to tell me.

John Samuel swallows.

JOHN SAMUEL

Ridge.

William looks up.

Nothing.

JOHN SAMUEL (CONT'D)

Not now.

William nods.

WILLIAM

Alright.

He picks up the bucket.

WILLIAM (CONT'D)

We go back slow.

JOHN SAMUEL

Why slow?

WILLIAM

Fast tells watchers they been seen.

John Samuel absorbs another rule.

EXT. HORNER HOMESTEAD — MORNING

Permelia plucks a chicken.

The sound is small, repetitive, unpleasant.

Mary Ann kneads dough or cuts bread.

Christopher sits too close to the doorway.

Permelia sees.

PERMELIA

Back.

Christopher scoots back a little.

PERMELIA (CONT'D)

More.

He scoots again.

MARY ANN

He's four.

PERMELIA

Then he can learn once.

Mary Ann says nothing.

Outside, Spencer checks the fence line near the yard.

He is trying not to look like he is watching the road.

He is watching the road.

EXT. RIDGE ROAD — SAME

The riders watch.

Jess shifts in the saddle.

The second rider leans forward.

SECOND RIDER

Old man's out.

JESS

Not far enough.

SECOND RIDER

How far you need him?

Jess looks toward the field.

Toward the slope.

Toward the edge of timber.

JESS

Far enough he can't get back.

A beat.

The second rider looks at the house.

SECOND RIDER

And the son?

Jess watches William and John Samuel walking back from the creek.

JESS

He'll run.

SECOND RIDER

You sound sure.

JESS

He knows better than the old man.

EXT. HORNER YARD — MOMENTS LATER

William and John Samuel return with water.

Mary Ann comes for the bucket.

William keeps hold of it for a beat.

MARY ANN
What?

WILLIAM
Keep them inside.

MARY ANN
You keep saying that.

WILLIAM
Keep doing it.

She takes the bucket.

Their hands touch around the handle.

Neither lets go immediately.

Not romance.

Fear.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — LATE MORNING

The house is full of forced work.

Mary Ann cooks.

Permelia trims, scrapes, orders, checks.

Christopher draws lines in the dirt.

John Samuel sits near the window.

William stands just inside the doorway.

Spencer enters.

SPENCER

We eat early.

No one argues.

The same line from Episode 1 returns, but now it has no pride in it.

Only calculation.

PERMELIA

Chicken's near done.

MARY ANN

Bread ain't.

SPENCER

Bread can be bread later.

Permelia looks at him.

That almost sounds like fear.

She does not comment.

EXT. ROAD BELOW RIDGE — DAY

A LOCAL MAN walks a mule along the lower road, not far from the Horner property.

He sees movement above him.

Riders in the timber.

He stops.

The riders see him seeing them.

Jess rides a few steps forward.

No weapon raised.

No need.

JESS

Morning.

LOCAL MAN

Morning.

The local man looks toward the Horner place.

Then back to Jess.

JESS

Road's better west.

LOCAL MAN

I was headed east.

JESS

Not today.

The local man holds his gaze.

Then turns his mule west.

He does not warn the Horners.

Fear is already doing its work.

EXT. MODERN WORKSPACE — DAY

Daniel at the table.

No dramatic music.

He has the phrase written from Episode 1:

INFORMATION MOVES BEFORE VIOLENCE

Now he adds below it:

FEAR MOVES TOO

Daniel places one finger on a map road near the homestead.

DANIEL (V.O.)

Sometimes silence is not conspiracy.

He pauses.

DANIEL (V.O.)

Sometimes silence is a man on a road deciding whether warning one family is worth risking his own.

Daniel looks at a blank place where a witness name should be.

DANIEL (V.O.)

The record almost never writes that man down.

Cut back.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — MIDDAY

The table is set.

Chicken.

Bread.

Beans.

A little molasses.

The same meal that should comfort.

It now feels like a countdown.

Christopher reaches.

Mary Ann catches his hand gently.

MARY ANN

Wait.

CHRISTOPHER

I'm hungry.

MARY ANN

I know.

John Samuel looks at the food but does not move.

Spencer enters and sees the table.

For a moment, he looks almost broken by the sight of it.

A family meal.

Still possible.

Still doomed.

William watches from the door.

SPENCER

Sit.

William hesitates.

SPENCER (CONT'D)

Sit.

William sits where he can still see the door.

Permelia notices.

Says nothing.

They begin to eat.

EXT. RIDGE ROAD — SAME

The riders sit hidden.

The second rider watches the house.

SECOND RIDER

They're eating.

Jess looks at the sun.

Looks at the field.

Looks at the yard.

JESS

Let them.

SECOND RIDER

You getting soft?

Jess turns to him.

No anger.

Just flat warning.

JESS

You want a man to run tired, you let him sit first.

The second rider looks back at the house.

Understands.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — CONTINUOUS

The family eats.

Small sounds.

Fork.

Plate.

Cup.

Breath.

Christopher eats quickly.

Spencer watches him.

SPENCER

Slow.

Christopher slows.

John Samuel does not eat.

William sees it.

WILLIAM

Bite.

John Samuel takes one.

Mary Ann's eyes are on the door.

Permelia's eyes are on Mary Ann.

Spencer tries to speak like normal life can be called back by voice.

SPENCER

Corn will need seeing after.

Nobody answers.

SPENCER (CONT'D)

Fence too.

Still nothing.

Spencer stops trying.

The room accepts silence.

EXT. HORNER HOMESTEAD — DAY

A dog barks somewhere distant.

The riders' horses shift in timber above.

The creek keeps moving.

The house sits below the ridge.

All routes visible now:

house

yard

field

potato patch

wooded hillside

cave country beyond

The geography of the coming violence is in place.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — CONTINUOUS

Christopher suddenly looks up.

CHRISTOPHER

I hear horses.

Everyone stops.

William stands.

Spencer stands.

Mary Ann reaches for Christopher.

Permelia turns toward John Samuel.

John Samuel is already at the window.

He looks out.

His face changes.

Not panic.

Recognition of the thing he has been waiting for.

JOHN SAMUEL

Not yet.

William turns to him.

WILLIAM

What?

John Samuel listens.

The sound fades.

JOHN SAMUEL

They stopped.

No one breathes right.

Spencer looks at William.

William looks at the door.

Permelia looks at the children.

The meal is over.

Even if food remains.

CUT TO BLACK.

END OF ACT ONE.